

Communication and Cooperation



Ethical Persuasion for Cooperation

The more skilled you are at communicating, the more often jobs will be done properly and finished on time.

In business terms you are a good manager, leader or organiser because you use persuasive communication to create co-operation.

Ethical persuasion should respect the rights, goals and emotions of everyone concerned. Creating co-operation should not involve the overriding of people's needs and getting whatever you want at any cost.

Consider these questions:

- A team leader wants their group to accept a new roster. The leader knows the new system will benefit all concerned, but to begin with nobody will agree. How far should the leader use powers of persuasion to make the group co-operate and accept the plan?
- Is it fair to use your skills as a communicator to persuade people to co-operate by paying their accounts on time?
- Is it fair to use the same skills to sell cosmetics at a party plan function to someone who has little need for the product and cannot afford it?
- Sometimes people who have your best interests at heart try to stop you doing something that could get you into trouble. How far should they go in using persuasion to prevent you doing it?

Why Don't People Cooperate?

Different goals. If people have goals that differ from yours or even if they think their goals are different, they will oppose you. One way of building co-operation and agreement is by logical reasoning.

Indirect opposition

Some people will resist or reject your requests without offering any clear reason or suggesting an alternative. They may be upset just because you and they do not agree, which makes it harder for them to co-operate. Persuasion based on sentiment or emotional appeal can help overcome this type of opposition.

Justifiable opposition

On some occasions people will have valid reasons for failure to co-operate. It is vital that you discover these reasons: if they are justifiable, you may be the one co-operating.

Unjustified opposition

Some people have selfish or unfair reasons for their unwillingness to co-operate. They are not interested in what you want.

Interpersonal Communication

There are four widely recognised and accepted styles of interpersonal communication.

- 1. Aggression**
- 2. Passivity**
- 3. Manipulativeness**
- 4. Assertiveness**

It is usually accepted that the first three styles are flawed.

They are :

- ineffective
- stressful
- counterproductive

1 Aggression

Meaning: Speaking in a forceful, rude, or disrespectful way. The person wants to win, even if it hurts others.

Example:

In a team meeting, John says loudly, “My idea is the best! If you don’t like it, you clearly don’t understand anything!”

2 Passivity

Meaning: Staying quiet and avoiding conflict. The person lets others make decisions, even if they feel uncomfortable.

Example:

Sara’s coworker takes credit for her work. She says nothing because she’s afraid of causing problems.

3. Manipulativeness

Meaning: Influencing others secretly or unfairly to get what they want.

Example:

Tom pretends to be sick to avoid a group project and makes others do the work, then joins at the end to take credit.

4. Assertiveness

Meaning: Expressing your thoughts, feelings, and needs clearly and respectfully. It's the healthiest style.

Example:

Lina tells her friend, "I understand your point, but I prefer we split the task equally so it's fair to both of us."

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Why the First Three Styles Are Considered Flawed:

1. Ineffective

They often fail to solve problems or build good relationships. People may not listen or respond well.

2. Stressful

These styles can create tension — for both the speaker and the listener. They may lead to arguments, misunderstandings, or guilt.

3. Counterproductive

Instead of helping, they usually make situations worse. For example, aggression might push people away, and manipulation can lead to mistrust.

"The most effective way to interact with other people is to adapt and use an assertive style."

Examples of Assertive Communication

- "I feel overwhelmed when I'm given last-minute tasks. Can we plan ahead next time?" (Expresses feelings and suggests a solution)
- "I respect your opinion, but I have a different point of view I'd like to share." (Shows respect and confidence)
- "I need more time to finish this report properly. Can we move the deadline by a day?" (Clearly asks for needs without being rude)
- "I'm not comfortable with that, but I'm happy to find another way that works for both of us." (Sets a boundary but stays open)
- "Let's all take turns speaking so everyone gets a chance." (Fair and direct in group settings)

Seven C's of Effective Communication by Francis J. Bergin

1. Clarity

Use simple, direct words so your message is easy to understand.

E.g., "I need your help with this task today."

2. Conciseness

Keep your message short and to the point.

Avoid unnecessary details or repetition.

3. Concreteness

Be specific and give facts or examples when needed.

E.g., "The report needs to include sales data from January to March."

4. Correctness

Use correct grammar, tone, and facts. This builds credibility and avoids confusion.

Seven C's of Effective Communication (continued)

5. Consideration

Be respectful and think about the other person's feelings and viewpoint.

E.g., “I understand you're busy, but could we find a time that works for both of us?”

6. Completeness

Every communication must be complete in itself. Incomplete messages keep the receiver guessing, create misunderstanding and delay actions. Messages must offer complete and relevant information in order to become effective. Incomplete information makes it necessary to begin another cycle of communication to issue clarification.

7. Courtesy

Be polite and positive, even when discussing problems.

E.g., “Thanks for your effort—I'd like to suggest one small change.”

These principles support assertive communication, helping people cooperate better by reducing misunderstandings and promoting mutual respect.

Barriers to Communication

The term barrier means hurdle, hindrance or obstacle. Thus, barriers to communication imply hurdles or obstacles on the way of transmission of message from the sender to the receiver. In practice, there exist several barriers in communication which render it ineffective. They generate confusion, conflict and misunderstanding in the organization by creating bottlenecks, delays and distortions of information.

1. Physical and Mechanical Barriers

a.) Noise – Noise is the disruption or interference in communication process anywhere along the process of communication. Noise can be sound of someone coughing, a truck driving by or two people talking nearby. All such noises lead to miscommunication and steps need to be taken to minimize them.

b.) Distance – Long distance between the senders and the receivers can also obstruct effective communication.

c.) Time – It refers to the reaching of message on time. If an important message reaches late, it is sure to effect communication.

d.) Information overload – It refers to excessive transmission of information. |

e.) Physical barriers – Outdated machines and equipment may produce excessive noise leading to physical barriers to communication to communication.

f.) Use of words with different meanings – Words used in communication may convey different meanings to different people. For example, the word tube may mean a fluorescent tube, cycle tube or a water tube.

g.) Denotations and Connotations – The literal meaning of the word is known by its denotative meaning. It just names the object without suggesting positive and negative qualities. Pen, book, chair, table and computer are some examples of denotative words. On the other hand connotative words like honest, punctual, competent and cheap arouse qualitative judgements. Some of these words like honest and competent have positive connotations. But other words like cheap and selfish have negative connotations.

2. Language or Semantic Barriers

a.) **Unclear message** – Lack of clarity and precision in a message makes it badly expressed. Poorly chosen and empty words and phrases, careless omission, bad organization of ideas are some of the faults found in this case.

b.) **Words or Symbols with different meanings** – A word may have several meanings. For example the word value may be used in the three different senses-

(1) The value of this book is Rs 200/-.

(2) We value our customers.

(3) The value of learning computer skills lies in the fact that jobs in industry are highly demanding.

c.) **Technical words or jargons** – It is often found that specialists and technical personnel tend to use the technical language of their respective fields.

d.) **Faulty translation** – Sometimes the instructions originally drafted in one language (e.g. English) need to be translated to the language understood by the workers (e.g. Hindi).

e.) **Unclarified assumptions** – Sometimes messages are based on certain assumptions which are subject to different interpretations.

f.) **Body language and gestures** – If the verbal communication is not matching with the body language, the listener may get confused and misunderstand the meaning.

3. Socio-Psychological Barriers

- a.) Differences in perception** – Perceptual barriers may arise due to differences between individuals in the way they perceive, organize and understand their environment.
- b.) Differences in attitude** – People differ with regard to attitudes and opinions which often interfere with communication.
- c.) Emotions** – How the receiver feels (emotion) at the time of receipt of information influences effectively how he interprets the information.
- d.) Inattention** – Communication has no impact on those who are unable or unwilling to listen attentively.
- e.) Closed minds** – One of the assumptions implicit in the communication process is that both the receiver and the sender have open minds, which enable them to process information in an uninhibited manner.
- f.) Premature evaluation** – Some people form a judgement before receiving the complete message. Such premature evaluation prevents effective communication.
- g.) Distrust** – It arises out of ill-considered judgements or illogical decisions or frequent countermanding of the original communication by the communicator.
- h.) Resistance to change** – It is a general tendency of human beings to maintain status quo. Thus resistance to change is an important obstacle to effective communication.
- i.) Cultural differences** – Cultural differences are faced when managers deal with people of different cultures.

4. Organizational Barriers

- a.) Status relationships** – Status refers to the regard and attitude displayed and held towards a position by the members of the organization. Organisation structure creates a number of status levels among the members of the organization.
- b.) One-way flow** – Where the flow of feedback from the receiver or the listener is blocked understanding will suffer. In fact one way communication in some situations is not communication at all.
- c.) Complex organization structure** – Complex organization structure creates problems because communication may breakdown at any level of supervision due to faulty transmission in order to overcome these difficulties.
- d.) Rigid rules and regulations** – Organizational rules and regulations affect the flow of communication by prescribing the subject matter to be communicated and also the channel through which these are to be communicated.
- e.) Distance barriers** – If both the communicator and communicatee are at distant places the communicatee fails to get immediate clarification required. Thus distance acts as a barrier to communication.
- f.) Physical barriers** - Communication becomes ineffective due to physical factors such as noise pollution of machines, vehicles and environment.
- g.) Mechanical barriers** - Any defect in the equipment used for communication may distort the impressions.

5. Personal Barriers

- a.) Attitude of superiors** - The attitude of superiors towards communication in general or in any particular direction affect the flow of information in different directions.
- b.) Lack of confidence in subordinates** – Superiors generally perceive that their subordinates are less competent and capable and that they are not able to advise superiors.
- c.) Insistence of proper channel** – One of the basic features of superiors' exercising of the authority is that they wish to remain in communication links and they do not like any type of bypassing in communication.
- d.) Ignoring Communication** – Sometimes superiors consciously and deliberately ignore the communication from their subordinates to maintain their importance.
- e.) Filtering of information** - Sometimes, the sender intentionally screens the information for passing only such information which will look favorable to the receiver.

The Communication Pyramid

The pyramid of communications shows how every message is interpreted through a complex network of attitudes, beliefs, prejudices, assumptions, ideas, associations, emotions and memories.

The Pareto principle can often apply to communication, as well as many other aspects of business, with up to 80% of a message being contributed by the receiver of the message.

The meanings we attach to messages represent the sum total of our experiences, social and cultural background, level of education, specialist knowledge, biases, prejudices and our emotional state at the moment the information is received.

This means that the same communication presented to a hundred different people may be interpreted by them in a hundred subtly different ways.

In many instances if you showed the same message to the same people a day later, their interpretation could be different.

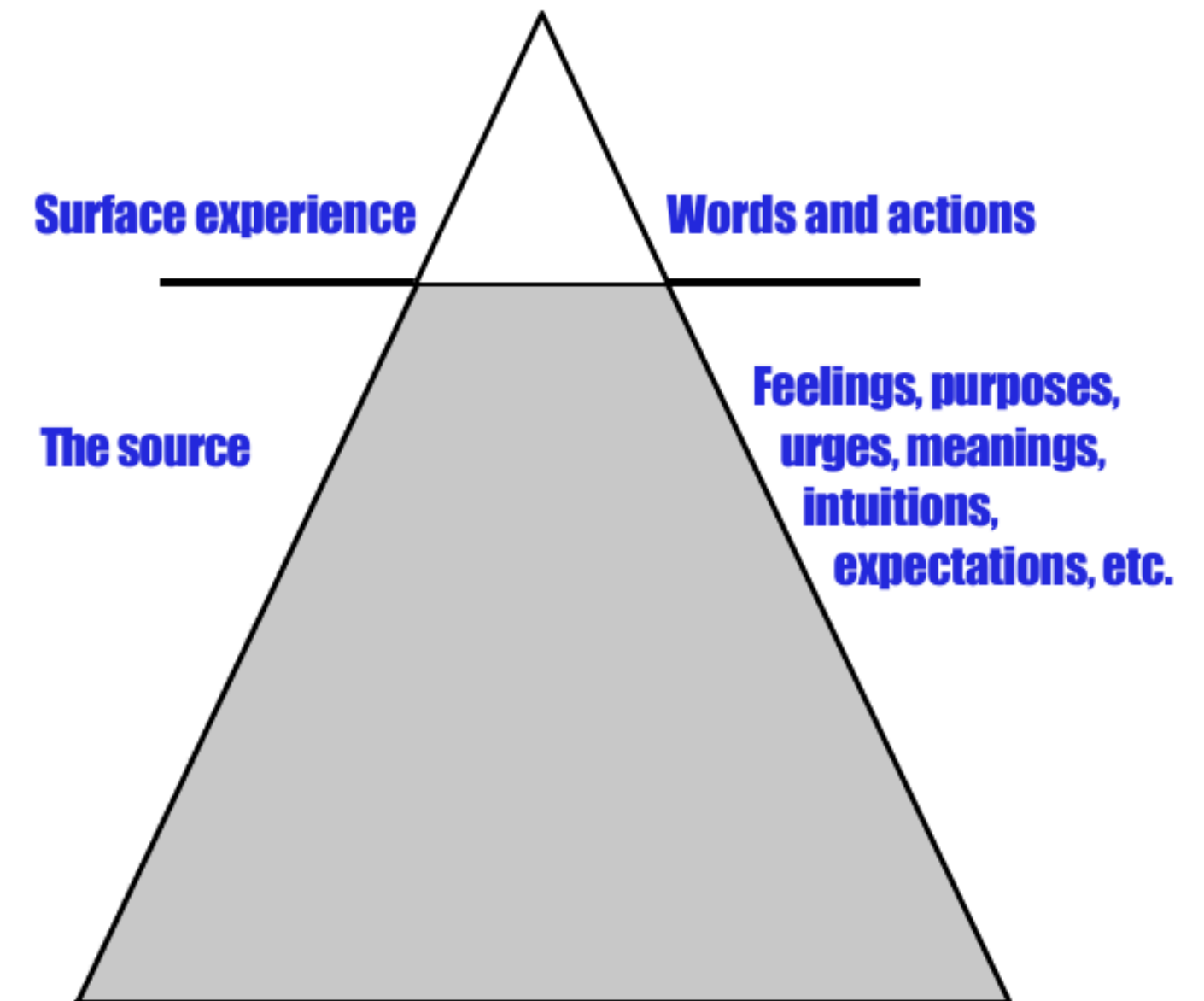
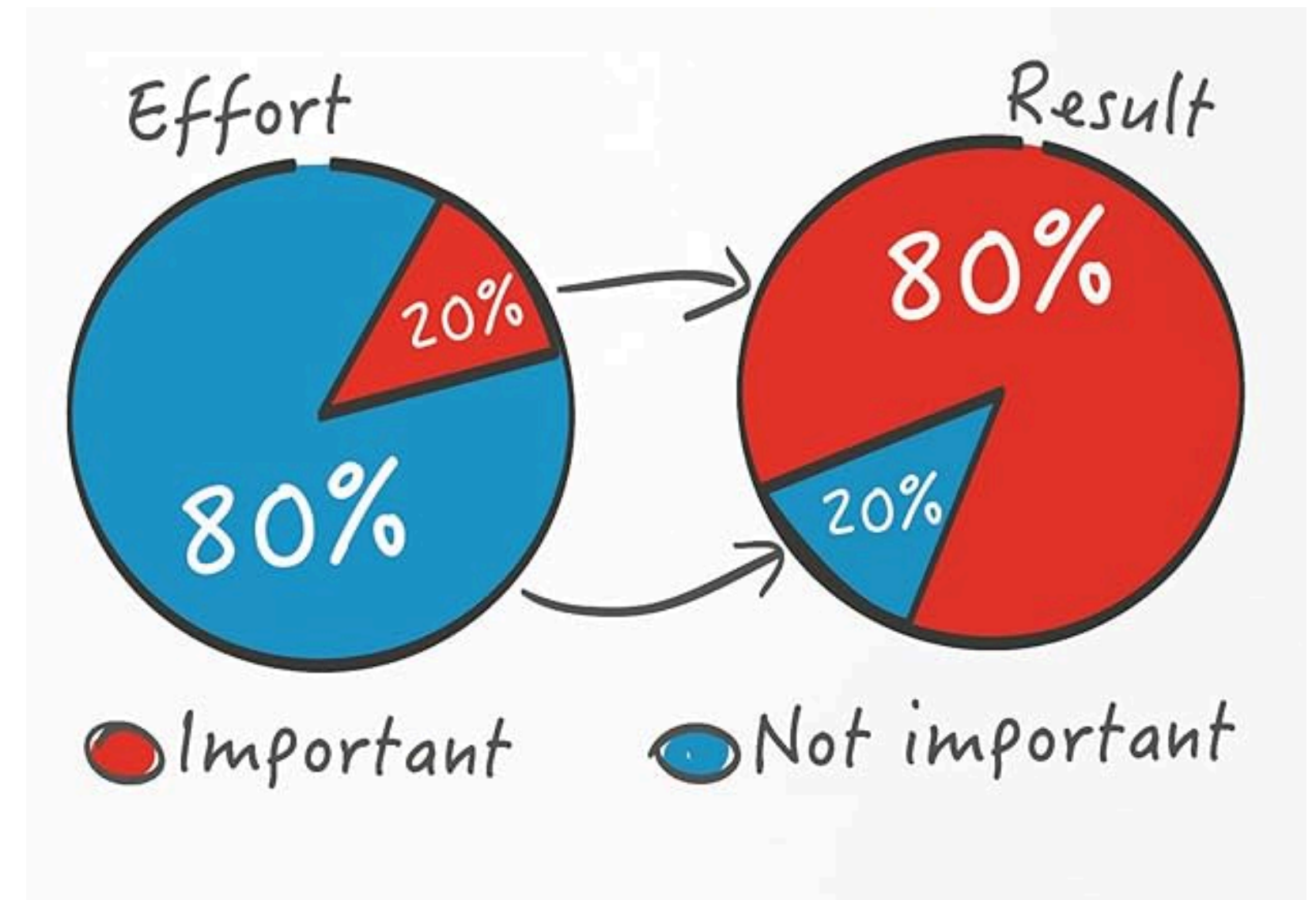


Fig. The Communication Pyramid

The Pareto Principle or The 80/20 Rule

The Pareto Principle, also known as the 80/20 Rule, was developed by economist Vilfredo Pareto. It suggests that 80% of results often come from just 20% of efforts. It's a useful way to focus on what matters most and improve productivity.



Pareto Principle in the Context of Communication

When applied to communication, the Pareto Principle means that a small portion of your communication style or content often has the biggest impact. For example:

- 20% of your message (the key points) might lead to 80% of understanding.
- 20% of your listening time may help you catch 80% of what truly matters in a conversation.
- 20% of the team's communicators may be responsible for 80% of the effective collaboration.

How to Apply It:

- Focus on key messages instead of overloading with details.
- Spend more time crafting the main points of a presentation or email.
- Listen actively to the critical parts of a discussion.
- Improve the most frequent communication habits that affect outcomes (tone, clarity, body language).

Thank You!